

TO THE POWER OF FOUR
Narendra Modi with the Australian PM, the US president and the Japanese premier in Tokyo



"The PM believes that the fundamentals of the India story remain strong and exudes confidence that his government will see the high growth it has set out to achieve. He wants to transform the economy. There is no going back on reforms."

– DR P.K. MISHRA, *Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister*

The focus in the remaining two years of Modi 2.0 has to be, as an expert put it, "Economy, Economy, Economy." Experts push for a more rapid integration of India into the global supply chains and to cash in on the sentiment expressed by most countries on having an alternative to China. States must play a key role in the endeavour, along with the Centre, and improve ease-of-doing-business norms and provide enabling infrastructure for businesses to grow. As a senior official put it, "The world wants India to succeed. We will not get this opportunity for the next 20 years at least. We must not miss the bus."

Having played a major part in ensuring that Uttar Pradesh voted overwhelmingly for the BJP government led by Yogi Adityanath, the win proved that Modi's personal popularity and people's trust in him remain high. Determined to go all out to maximise economic growth, Modi is now focusing on implementation. Dr Mishra says, "The prime minister has told all of us that we should focus on ensuring efficient delivery and implementation of all the schemes that have been launched." Experts say that for rapid economic growth, Modi must spend the next two years unifying the country towards that goal. They caution him against allowing fringe elements in the Sangh parivar to raise another mandir vs masjid demon, as is happening in Varanasi and Mathura, and derail his economic development agenda. You cannot preach religion to empty stomachs. Modi has to grow the economy, improve incomes and usher in prosperity, apart from ensuring that the country is at peace with itself. That requires picking the best economic advisors, plenty of policy planning and focused implementation. Modi is on the verge of history—of becoming one of the greatest prime ministers that India has had. He must either grab the opportunity and guide India to its rightful place under the sun or prepare to be remembered as just another prime minister. ■